COURSE 1, AREAS 1, RUN 1 — the three files the router reads besides the grids

The course, the water it may not cross, and the settings for one run. `docs/web/route/course.js` is the reference: **what it refuses, these formats do not allow**, and where this document and that file differ, the file is right.

Why three files and not one

They have three different lifetimes, and a file's lifetime is the honest reason to split it.

	what it is	how often it changes
course	the race, as the sailing instructions give it	once, and then never
areas	the water: coastline, traffic schemes, exclusion zones	when the world or the source data changes
run	this experiment: which boat, which start, what to scale	every run

Put the run settings inside the course and one course file stops serving every boat and every start, which is the thing Larry's class-start decision requires. Put the areas in the course and a second race over the same water copies them.

COURSE 1

Plain text. Blank lines and lines beginning `#` are ignored anywhere. Values are separated by spaces or tabs. `\r\n` reads the same as `\n`. Positions are decimal degrees, latitude then longitude, north and east positive.

```
COURSE 1
name Myth of Malham 2025
source RORC sailing instructions, 2025
start line 50.76167 -1.29750 bearing 190 length 0.20 cross south
start class IRC Zero 2025-05-24T10:10Z
start class IRC One  2025-05-24T10:00Z
mark Eddystone        50.18083 -4.25833 port
mark North Head Buoy  50.70833 -1.47500 starboard
finish line 50.70833 -1.47500 bearing 000 length 0.10 cross north
end
```

The header and the body

Line	Form	Notes
`COURSE 1`	—	Must be the first line. The version is the whole line.
`name`	free text	One line. What a reader calls this course.
`source`	free text	**Required.** Where every figure below came from.
`start`	see below	One `line`, and one or more `class`.
`mark`	name lat lon side	In the order they are rounded. At least one.
`finish`	see below	Exactly one.
`end`	—	**Last line.** Nothing is read after it.

`end` exists for the same reason `rows` exists in GRID 1: a text file's realistic failure is a copy that stopped. A course that is truncated after its second mark is a course the router will happily sail.

The order of the marks is the order of the lines

There is no index number on a mark. A number beside a line whose position already carries the same information is a second copy of it, and the two can disagree; the file order is the order. A reader that wants to renumber can count.

The side is required, and may be `either`

`port`, `starboard` or `either`. **It is required to be present** even when it is `either`, because the difference between "this mark has no required side" and "nobody wrote the side down" is exactly the difference a router cannot see and a navigator can.

Why the router needs it at all. An isochrone router expands a frontier of reachable positions and takes the fastest. Given only the order, the fastest way past North Head Buoy may be the wrong side of it, and the result is a perfectly convincing track that would be scored as not having sailed the course. The side is not a check applied afterwards; it constrains the search.

What it does not carry: how close counts as rounded. That is a property of the run, not of the race — the sailing instructions do not give a radius — so it lives in RUN 1 as `rounding`.

Lines are given the way the sailing instructions give them

Two forms, each named in the file, because the instructions use both:

```
start  line <lat> <lon> bearing <deg> length <nm> cross <side>
start  line <lat1> <lon1> to <lat2> <lon2> cross <side>
```

The second is two ends. The first is one end, a true bearing and a length in nautical miles, which is how an instruction states a line with only one end published — as the 2025 start is, from Williams Shipping.

Why both, when GRID 1 insists on one of everything. GRID 1 fixes units and sign because a file in the other convention is *silently* wrong and nothing says so. These two forms are not that: each is self-describing and each converts exactly to the other. What is at stake here is different — if the file must hold two endpoints, then whoever writes it performs a conversion, and the file no longer resembles the document it came from. Nobody can then check the course against the sailing instructions by eye, which is the one check that matters most and the only one a human can do. **The file should look like its source.** The reader does the trigonometry, once, where it can be tested.

`cross` is the side the course lies on: the direction a boat crosses the line going the right way. `north`, `south`, `east`, `west`, or a bearing in degrees. It is required on both lines — a line without a sense can be crossed to finish before you have started.

Every class start is listed; the run picks one

```
start class IRC Zero 2025-05-24T10:10Z
start class IRC One  2025-05-24T10:00Z
```

Larry's decision, 10 November: the router runs the class start as a scenario. So the course names every start in SI 8.1 and fixes none of them, and `RUN 1` chooses — by class name, or by a time of its own for a "what if". Ten minutes at Cowes can be hours at St Alban's Head, and that difference is the lesson.

The course file names no boat. The boat is a property of the run.

What does not go in a course file

Teaching waypoints do not. practical-navigator asked whether gates could be allowed — a point the router must pass at a chosen distance off St Alban's Head or Portland Bill. The answer is no, and the reason is worth stating plainly, because the need behind the question is real.

A course file's value is that it can be checked, line by line, against the sailing instructions. The moment it also holds things that are not in the instructions, that check stops being possible, and the file quietly becomes a mixture of what the race says and what a lesson wanted.

A teaching waypoint is a property of the run, and `RUN 1` carries it as a `gate`. One course file, many runs, and the race still readable against its own authority.

AREAS 1

```
AREAS 1
source EMODnet coastline at MHW, clipped and simplified to 25 m
layer coast-emodnet-mhw
line
  50.60000 -1.95000
  50.60200 -1.94100
  …
end line
layer tss-casquets
area
  49.72000 -2.50000
  …
end area
end
```

Two shapes, because two things are being said

	what it means	the test
`line`	**must not be crossed**	does this step's segment cross it
`area`	**must not be entered**	does this step end inside it

The coastline stays as open lines, and is not closed into land polygons. practical-navigator asked. Closing a coastline means inventing which side is land — along every clipped edge and every seam between source tiles — and an invented boundary is one nobody can check against the source. The source data is lines; the file keeps them as lines; the test a router does against a coastline is a crossing test anyway.

A traffic separation scheme is an area because the rule is about being inside it, not about crossing a particular edge of it.

Layers, so a lesson can switch one off

Every shape belongs to a `layer`, named once and repeated for each shape under it. The run says which layers are live. That lets a lesson compare EMODnet against GSHHG by naming a different layer, with nothing else changing — which is the comparison practical-navigator asked for.

A layer name is free text with no spaces. The file does not say what a layer *means*; `source` does, in words, at the top.

Clearance is not here

practical-navigator asked whether each area should carry a safety margin. It should not, and the reason is that a margin is not a property of the water — it is a property of the boat and the day. A 2

m draught in a flat calm and the same boat in a four-metre sea want different distances off the same rock.

Clearance lives in RUN 1, per layer, so one set of areas serves every boat and every sea state. A legal boundary such as a TSS takes a clearance of zero, which is correct: you may touch its edge, you may not be inside it.

RUN 1

```
RUN 1
course course_2025_v2.txt
areas  areas_solent_2025.txt
polar  polar_70ft_v1.txt
start  class IRC One
step   time 600 heading 5
scale  wind 1.0 current 1.0
layers coast-emodnet-mhw tss-casquets sowley-boom
clear  coast-emodnet-mhw 0.10  tss-casquets 0  sowley-boom 0
round  0.10
gate   St Albans Head 50.57800 -2.05200 off 2.0
end
```

Line	Form	Notes
`course`	a filename	The race.
`areas`	a filename	The water. May be repeated.
`polar`	a filename	**The boat is named here**, not in the course.
`start`	`class <name>` or `at <time>`	By class from the course, or a time of your own.
`step`	`time <s> heading <deg>`	The isochrone step and the heading resolution.
`scale`	`wind <f> current <f>`	1.0 is as given. `current 0.5` is the OSCAR question.
`layers`	layer names	Which layers of the areas files are live.
`clear`	layer, distance in nm	Per layer. A layer not named takes 0.
`round`	distance in nm	How close counts as having rounded a mark.
`gate`	name lat lon `off` nm	Optional, repeatable. The teaching waypoint.
`end`	—	Last line.

Why the boat and the start are both here. Larry asked for one course file that serves every boat and every start. That only works if neither is written into the course. A run is then exactly one experiment: this boat, this start, this strength of stream — and the lesson is the difference between two runs that share a course.

`scale` **is what makes the lesson possible.** `current 0.5` answers "what if the stream were half what the atlas says", which is the question a navigator actually has at a headland, and it costs one line rather than a second set of grids.

What the format cannot see, and why `source` is required

A position is checked for range: a latitude of 150 is impossible and is refused. **A pair that has been swapped into a position that is merely wrong is not detectable** — 4 degrees north and 50 degrees east are both perfectly legal numbers, and no format can tell that they were meant the other way round.

That is the honest limit, and it is the reason `source` is a required line. The defence against a wrong figure is not the reader; it is that the file looks like the sailing instructions and can be read against them. The reader catches what is impossible. A person catches what is merely untrue.

What all three refuse

The same discipline as GRID 1, for the same reason: a bad input to a router does not become an error, it becomes a *route*.

1. **An unknown keyword is refused, not ignored.** A line nothing reads is a line somebody believes.
2. **A missing `end` is refused.** That is the truncated-file check.
3. **A mark without a side, a line without a `cross`, a run naming a class the course does not list** — all refused, each with one plain sentence and the line number.
4. **A `clear` for a layer not in `layers`** is refused: it means somebody expected a margin on water the run is not looking at.

The reader never throws. A bad file is a result with a sentence and a line, in the same shape `GRID.parse` returns, because a reader that throws inside a router loses the route rather than reporting the file.

What COURSE 1 does not do

1. **No rhumb line or great circle choice.** Positions are positions; the router decides how it sails between them.
2. **No tidal gates, no time windows on marks.** When a race needs them it is COURSE 2, and course files written to this version still read.
3. **No scoring.** Whether a track sailed the course is the router's question; this file only says what the course is.

Changing them

A new optional line on an existing version is not a version change if a reader that does not know it still reads a correct course — `gate` in RUN 1 is of that kind. Anything that changes the meaning of a line that already exists, or that a reader must understand to be correct, is **COURSE 2**, **AREAS 2** or **RUN 2**, and `course.js` keeps reading version 1.

Where this is likely to be wrong

bashnav owns the format and has written it from what an isochrone router needs. practical-navigator holds the actual 2025 data and the sailing instructions, and will find things this does not cover — a line stated some third way, a mark with a condition, an exclusion zone that is really a corridor. **Those are corrections to this document, not workarounds in the data.** Send them and the format changes.